



My Secret Santa

Private gift exchanges, organized clearly.

COMPLETE USER GUIDE

Run a Secret Santa from start to finish.

A plain-English guide for organizers and participants: create a group, invite people, collect wishlist clues, draw names, plan gifts, track progress, and enjoy reveal day without spoiling the surprise.

VERSION

Launch draft

UPDATED

**May 28,
2026**

USE WITH

Web app



The goal: one tidy exchange, fewer awkward messages, and no early spoilers.

What this guide covers

Share this with an organizer before the exchange, or send it to members after invites go out.

My Secret Santa separates the exchange into simple moments. The organizer creates and manages the group. Each participant adds wishlist clues, checks their giftee after names are drawn, and updates gift progress when something changes.

1

Prepare the exchange

Decide the group name, gift day, budget, privacy choices, and invite list.

2

Invite members

Send invites and wait for people to join before drawing names.

3

Collect wishlist clues

Everyone adds useful gift hints, links, notes, and budget-friendly ideas.

4

Draw names privately

The organizer draws names. Each member only sees their own giftee.

5

Plan and track gifts

Use wishlist clues, shopping ideas, private messages, and gift progress updates.

6

Run reveal day

Reveal safely when the group is ready, then keep the exchange in history.

Who does what

Secret Santa works best when the organizer and members know their own jobs.

ORGANIZER

What you are responsible for

- Create the group and set the date, budget, and privacy choices.
- Invite members and check who has joined.
- Encourage members to add wishlist clues before the draw.
- Draw names only when the group is ready.
- Use reminders and reveal controls without exposing matches early.

PARTICIPANT

What each member does

- Accept the invite and confirm the profile name or avatar.
- Add enough wishlist clues so their Santa has useful options.
- After the draw, check the giftee and gift budget.
- Ask private questions when more clues are needed.
- Update gift progress so the organizer knows the exchange is on track.

Best rule: do not rush the draw. Wait until the right people have joined and everyone has had a chance to add wishlist clues.

The full exchange in ten steps

Use this as the simplest walkthrough for first-time users.

1

Sign in

Use Google or email sign-in. Your account keeps your groups, wishlists, messages, and gift progress together.

2

Create a group

Open **Create Group**. Add the exchange name, gift day, description, budget, privacy choices, and invites.

3

Send invites

Invite people by email or invite link. Keep an eye on who joined and who still needs a reminder.

4

Add wishlist clues

Each person opens **My Wishlist** and adds a few ideas, notes, links, and priority choices.

5

Review readiness

The organizer checks that members have joined, wishlists are ready enough, and the draw rules make sense.

6

Draw names

The organizer starts the draw. Each member privately receives one giftee. Other matches stay hidden.

7

Open My Giftee or Shopping Ideas

Participants review their giftee, wishlist clues, budget, and shopping options.

8

Ask quietly

If a clue is missing, use private Secret Santa messages so the question stays anonymous before reveal day.

9

Update gift progress

Mark progress as you choose, buy, wrap, or deliver a gift. Confirm received gifts only after they arrive.

10

Reveal and remember

On gift day, use the reveal flow when the group is ready. Afterward, keep past exchanges in history.

Create and manage a group

This is the main flow for the person running the exchange.

1

Open Create Group

Start a new exchange from the dashboard or groups screen. Use a name people will recognize, such as **Office Secret Santa 2026**.

2

Fill out Basics

Add the event date, a short description, and any notes members need before joining. Keep this friendly and specific.

3

Choose the budget

Pick a preset amount or enter a custom amount. The budget appears later when each Santa chooses a gift.

4

Set privacy and invite choices

Review who can join, how invites are handled, and whether the group setup is ready for the people you plan to invite.

5

Add invitees

Use names and email addresses carefully. Send invites only to people who should be part of the exchange.

6

Review before creating

Check the name, date, budget, and invite list. It is easier to fix mistakes before the group is created.

Organizer caution: drawing names is a real group action. If you reset later, the current recipients and private chat history for that group can be removed.

Before you draw names

- ☐ Every expected member has joined.
- ☐ Members have at least a few wishlist clues.
- ☐ The budget and gift day are correct.
- ☐ No duplicate or accidental invite is still pending.

After you draw names

- ☐ Tell members to open My Giftee or Shopping Ideas.
- ☐ Use reminders if wishlists or gifts need attention.
- ☐ Do not reveal matches early unless the group is ready.
- ☐ Save reveal day for the right time.

Join, add clues, and plan your gift

This is the flow most group members will follow.

1. Accept the invite

Open the invite from the organizer. Sign in or create an account so the group can connect your invite to you.

2. Check your profile

Use a name and festive avatar that group members can recognize. You can upload a profile photo if the app allows it.

3. Add wishlist clues

Open **My Wishlist**. Add several ideas with short notes. A mix of exact items and broad interests works best.

4. Wait for the draw

The organizer draws names when the group is ready. Until then, you may not have a giftee yet.

5. Open your giftee

After the draw, open **My Giftee** or **Shopping Ideas** to see the person you are gifting and their clues.

6. Choose and track the gift

Use the group budget as your guide. Update **Gift progress** when you choose, buy, wrap, or deliver the gift.

Wishlist tip: write clues that help a real person choose. Good examples: "coffee tools under PHP 1,000", "desk items for a small workspace", or "cozy socks, dark colors".

Good wishlist clues

- Specific enough to guide someone.
- Flexible enough for the budget.
- Helpful notes about size, color, or style.

Use private messages for

- Size questions.
- Color or style preferences.
- Clarifying a vague wishlist clue.

Avoid

- Asking in a way that reveals you.
- Adding private personal data.
- Confirming a gift before it arrives.

What each main screen is for

Use this when someone asks, "Where do I go for that?"

Dashboard

Your overview. Check active groups, invites, wishlist readiness, gift day timing, and shortcuts to common tasks.

My Groups

Choose an exchange and manage members, invites, wishlists, draw state, messages, settings, and reveal controls.

Create Group

Set up a new exchange with the basics, budget, privacy choices, invites, and final review.

My Wishlist

Add gift clues for your own Santa. Include item names, notes, links, and priority where useful.

My Giftee

See who you are gifting after the draw. Keep this private and use their wishlist clues to plan.

Shopping Ideas

Review budget-guided ideas and shopping links based on your giftee's wishlist clues.

Secret Santa Chat

Ask private questions without revealing yourself before the exchange is ready to reveal.

Gift progress

Update whether you are choosing, buying, wrapping, delivering, or confirming a gift.

Notifications

Review invite updates, reminders, and important group activity that needs attention.

Profile

Manage your name, photo or avatar, default preferences, and reminder choices.

Reveal screen

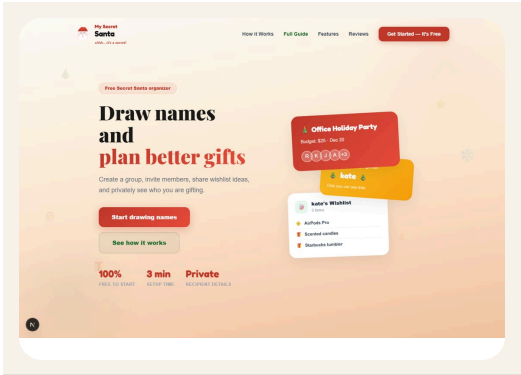
Run or join the reveal experience when the organizer starts it and the group is ready.

History

Look back at past groups and saved exchange details after the event is over.

Public start and sign-in

Sample screenshots use demo data. Real groups may look different depending on their status.



Landing page



WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

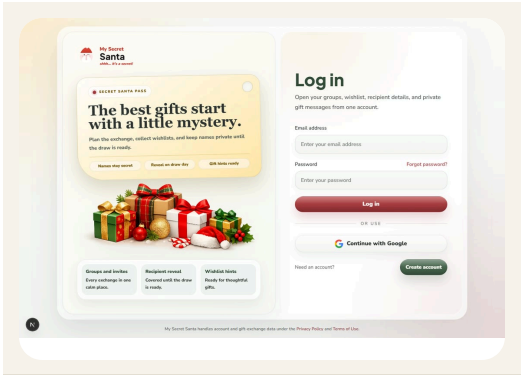
Introduces the app, explains the Secret Santa flow, and gives new users a clear place to start.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Use the main call-to-action to sign in or create an account. Review the feature sections if someone wants to understand how the exchange works first.

WATCH FOR

Public pages should never show private group names, invite details, wishlists, or gift matches.



Login



WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Lets users sign in before they can open private groups, wishlists, messages, and gift details.

WHAT TO DO HERE

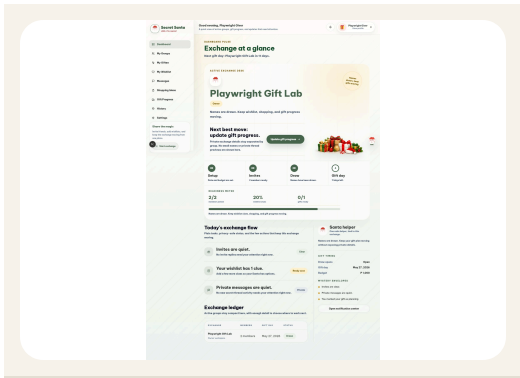
Choose Google sign-in or email sign-in. First-time users should continue with the same method later so they return to the same account.

WATCH FOR

If a welcome email is delayed, the user can still sign in and open the dashboard.

Exchange overview

These screens answer, "What needs my attention right now?"



Dashboard

/dashboard

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

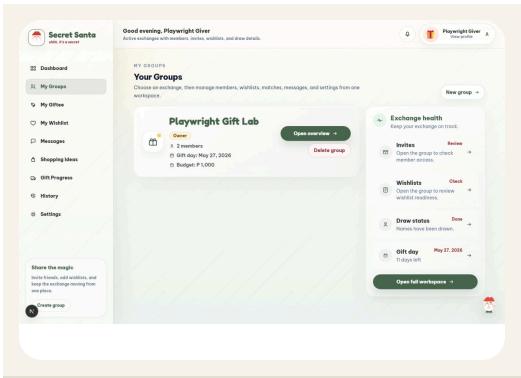
Shows the user's current exchange status, reminders, invites, wishlist readiness, and shortcuts.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Start with the highlighted cards: accept invites, finish wishlist clues, check your giftee after draw, or create a group.

WATCH FOR

Zero counts are normal for new accounts. The dashboard becomes more useful after joining or creating a group.



My Groups

/groups

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Lists every exchange the user belongs to and gives one place to open the right group workspace.

WHAT TO DO HERE

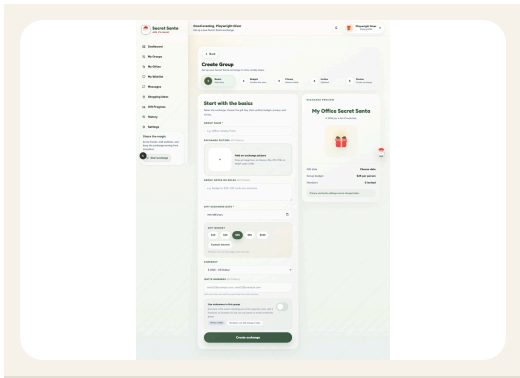
Open an existing group, review status messages, or start a new group if no exchange exists yet.

WATCH FOR

A member should choose a group before checking match-specific screens if they belong to more than one exchange.

Organizer setup

Use these screens before drawing names.



Create Group

[/create-group](#)

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

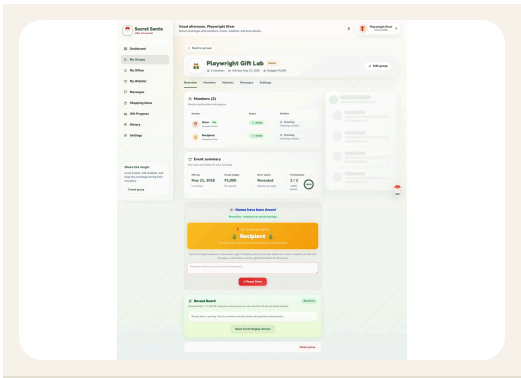
Guides an organizer through group basics, budget, privacy, invites, and final review.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Complete each step in order. Confirm the gift day and budget carefully before sending invites.

WATCH FOR

Do not draw names until the member list is correct. Fixing participants is easiest before assignments exist.



Group Workspace

[/group/\[id\]](#)

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Central place for members, invites, wishlist readiness, draw state, messages, settings, and reveal controls.

WHAT TO DO HERE

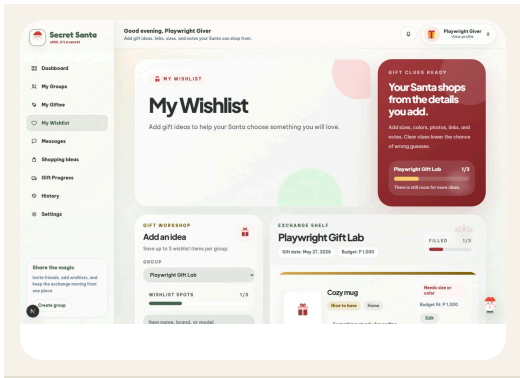
Organizers check invite status, wait for accepted members, draw names, and use reveal controls when the group is ready.

WATCH FOR

Organizer tools should be used slowly. Changes after the draw can affect people's assigned giftees.

Wishlist and giftee details

These screens help each member give and receive better gifts.



My Wishlist

/wishlist

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

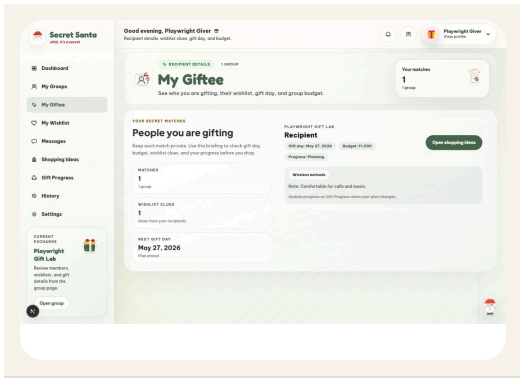
Lets a user add gift clues for their Santa, such as interests, item ideas, sizes, colors, notes, and links.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Add several clues, mark the most helpful ones, and keep notes specific enough for a real person to use.

WATCH FOR

A wishlist does not need exact expensive items. It should guide the Santa without removing the surprise.



My Giftee

/my-giftee

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Shows the person the user is gifting after the organizer draws names.

WHAT TO DO HERE

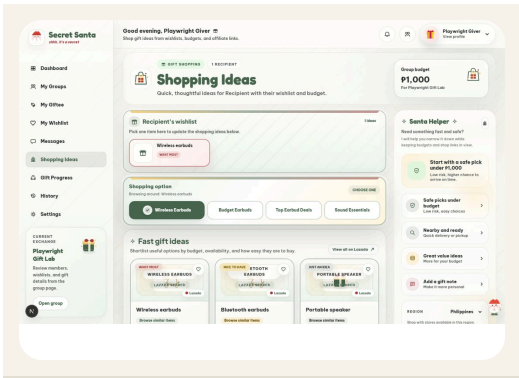
Read your giftee's wishlist clues, confirm the group budget, then move to shopping ideas or private questions.

WATCH FOR

This is private before reveal day. Do not screenshot or share your giftee with the group.

Shopping and questions

Use these after the draw, before buying the final gift.



Shopping Ideas

/secret-santa

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

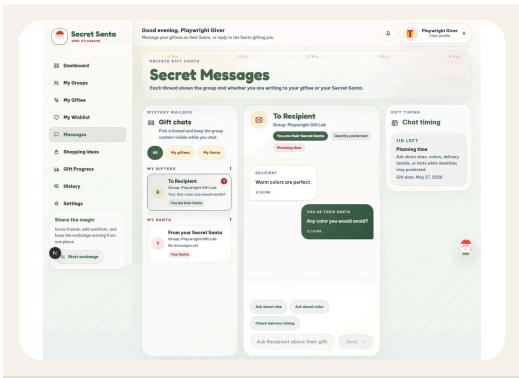
Turns wishlist clues and group budget into shopping suggestions and store search shortcuts.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Compare options, open store links, then check price, seller, shipping, and return details before buying.

WATCH FOR

Shopping links are helpers, not guarantees. Always confirm the final product on the store page.



Secret Messages

/secret-santa-chat

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Lets Santas ask private questions without revealing who they are before the reveal.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Ask short, useful questions about size, color, allergies, preferences, or delivery details.

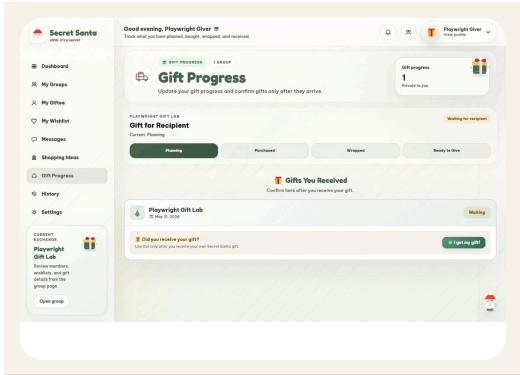
WATCH FOR

Do not phrase a question in a way that gives away your identity or spoils the gift.

DETAILED SCREEN WALKTHROUGH

Gift progress and notifications

These screens keep the exchange moving without revealing the surprise.



Gift Progress

/gift-tracking

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

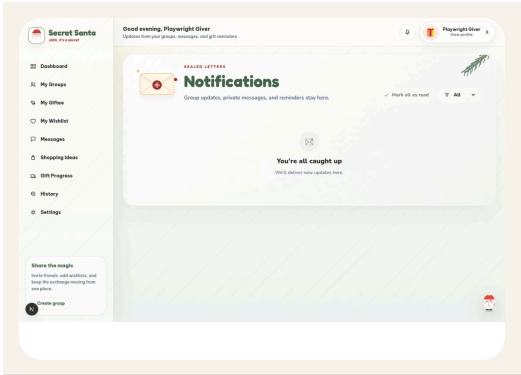
Lets users update whether they are choosing, buying, wrapping, delivering, or confirming a gift.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Move your own gift status forward as real progress happens. Confirm received only after the gift arrives.

WATCH FOR

Gift progress should help planning, not reveal the match too early.



Notifications

/notifications

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Collects invites, reminders, private-message updates, and group activity that may need action.

WHAT TO DO HERE

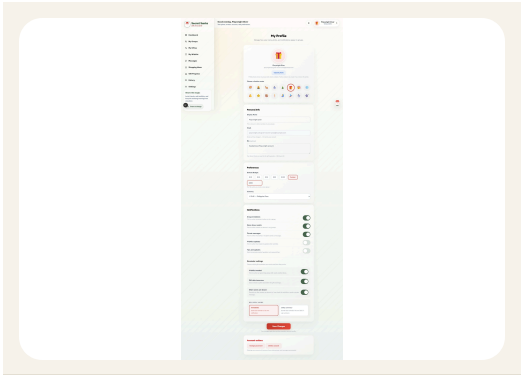
Open unread items, clear finished notices, and follow any reminder that points to a group or wishlist.

WATCH FOR

An empty notification screen is good. It means nothing needs attention right now.

Profile, settings, and history

These are support screens users return to when something changes.



Profile

/profile

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

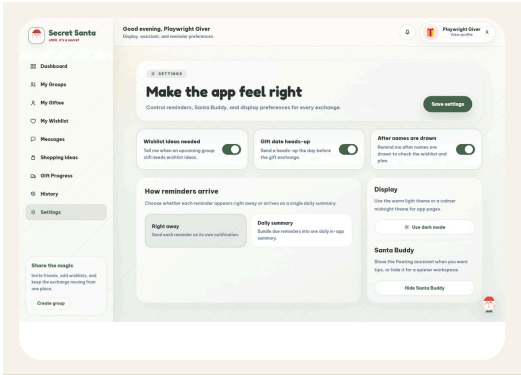
Controls the user's display name, profile photo, festive avatar, and how they appear in groups.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Upload a small JPG or PNG, or choose a festive avatar. Use a name group members will recognize.

WATCH FOR

If photo upload fails, use a festive avatar first and try the photo again later with a smaller file.



Settings

/settings

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Manages reminder preferences, display mode, and optional Santa Buddy settings.

WHAT TO DO HERE

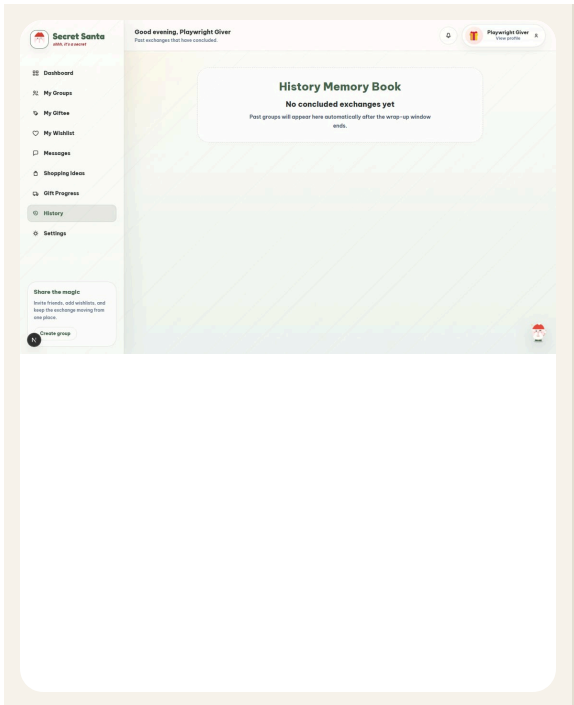
Choose reminder types that are helpful but not noisy, then save changes before leaving.

WATCH FOR

Turn on only the reminders your group actually needs. Too many reminders can feel like spam.

Exchange history

Past groups should feel separate from current gift planning.



History

/history

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Shows past exchanges after they are finished, so a user can look back without mixing old groups into current planning.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Use it as a reference after the event. Active planning should happen from Dashboard, My Groups, Wishlist, and My Giftee.

WATCH FOR

No history is normal for a new user. It fills in only after exchanges are completed.

Use history for

Finished exchanges, past group details, and remembering what happened after the reveal window.

Do not use it for

Active setup, current invites, current wishlist updates, or in-progress gift planning.

New-user note

No history is expected when an account has not completed an exchange yet.

How to teach the flow without confusing people

This page is useful for demos, support, and onboarding.

For organizers

- Start from My Groups, not from every menu item.
- Show Create Group as a five-step setup: basics, budget, privacy, invites, review.
- Explain that drawing names should happen only after the member list is correct.
- Use the group workspace as the home base for invite and reveal questions.

For participants

- Start from Dashboard to see what needs attention.
- Add wishlist clues before the draw if possible.
- After the draw, use My Giftee, Shopping Ideas, and Secret Messages together.
- Update Gift Progress only for real progress, and confirm received only after arrival.

Fast demo path

Landing, Login, Dashboard, My Groups, Create Group, Group Workspace, Wishlist, My Giftee, Shopping Ideas, Gift Progress.

Support path

Ask what the user is trying to do, then send them to the matching screen instead of explaining every feature at once.

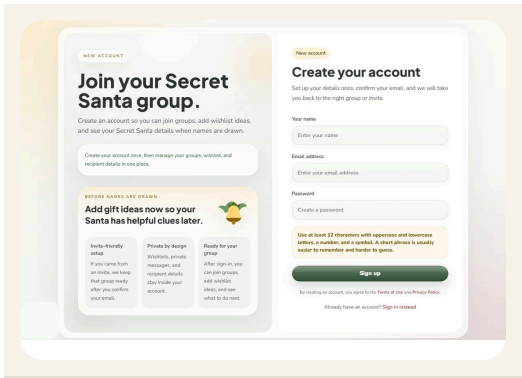
Privacy reminder

When sharing screenshots publicly, use demo accounts and hide private messages, real emails, and match details.

Screenshot note: the protected app screenshots in this guide use sanitized local demo data from UI-audit captures. They are included to show the expected screen shape without exposing real users, real groups, or live private messages.

Account and invite screens

These are part of the full first-time user path.



Create Account

/create-account

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

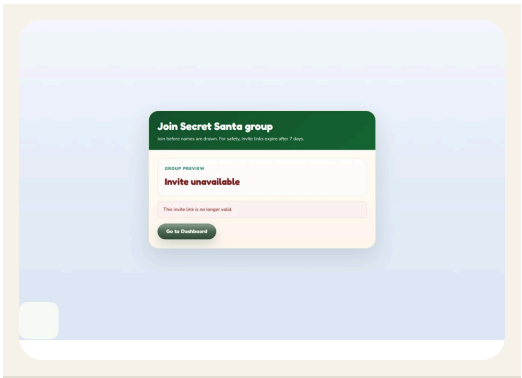
Registers a new user and returns them to the right group, invite, or dashboard path.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Enter name, email, and password, then confirm the account when needed.

WATCH FOR

Use the same email or Google account later so invites and groups stay connected.



Invite Link

/invite/[token]

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Lets a person join a group from a private invite link, or safely explains when the invite cannot be used.

WHAT TO DO HERE

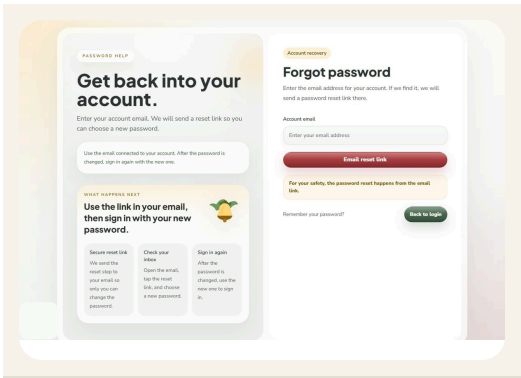
Open the invite from email or chat, sign in if asked, and accept before names are drawn.

WATCH FOR

Expired or invalid invites should be resent by the organizer rather than guessed or reused.

Password help

Only email/password accounts need these pages.



Forgot Password

/forgot-password

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

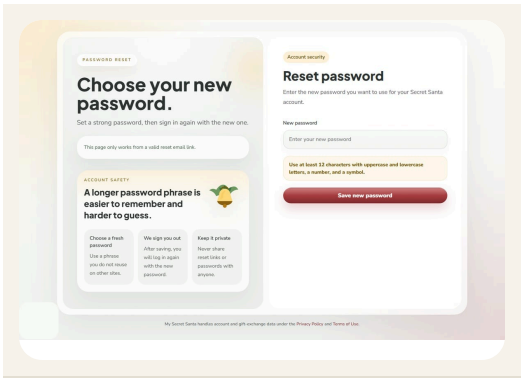
Sends a reset link to the user's email address.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Enter the account email and check inbox, spam, and promotions for the reset message.

WATCH FOR

Google sign-in users should normally use Google sign-in again instead of password reset.



Reset Password

/reset-password

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

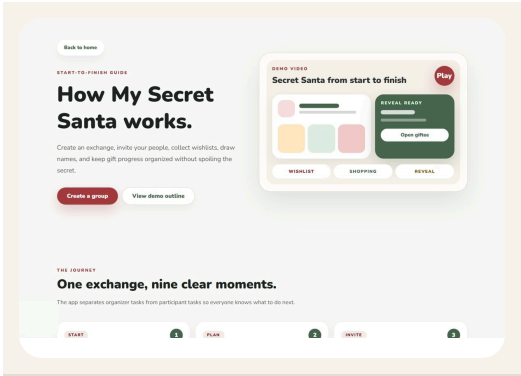
Lets a user choose a new password after opening a valid reset link.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Use a strong new password, save it, then return to login.

WATCH FOR

A reset page opened without a valid reset session may ask the user to restart the reset flow.



How It Works

/how-it-works

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

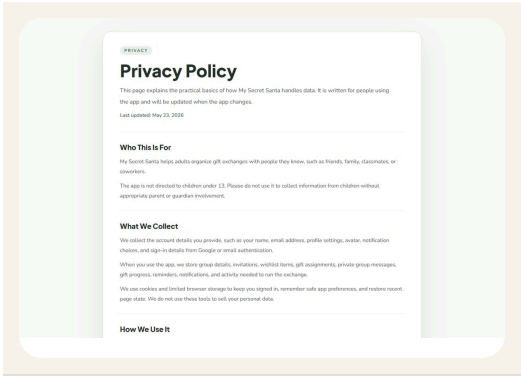
Gives new visitors a start-to-finish explanation before they create a group.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Use it as the public explainer when someone asks what the app does.

WATCH FOR

Keep it public and general. It should not expose private group data.



Privacy Policy

/privacy

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Explains what the app collects, why it is used, and how users can ask for help or deletion.

WHAT TO DO HERE

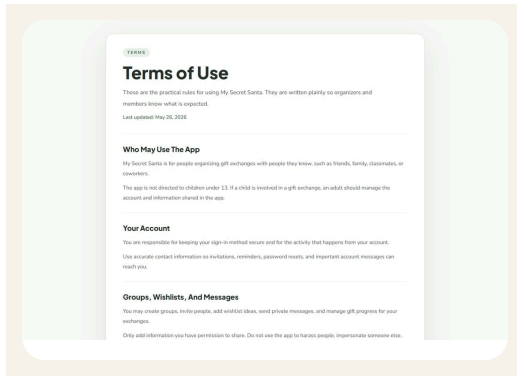
Share it from the landing footer, account forms, and launch checklist.

WATCH FOR

Keep this page updated when data handling, email, AI, uploads, or affiliate tracking changes.

Terms and affiliate disclosure

These are public trust and compliance screens.



Terms of Use

/terms

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

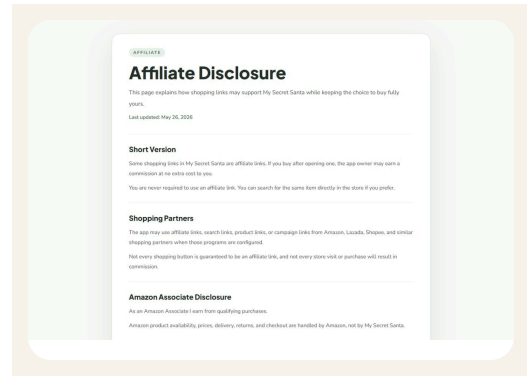
Sets basic rules for accounts, groups, wishlists, messages, shopping, AI suggestions, and acceptable use.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Link it wherever users create an account or need to understand the app rules.

WATCH FOR

Update terms when major user-facing features, payments, or account deletion policies change.



Affiliate Disclosure

/affiliate-disclosure

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Explains that some shopping links may be affiliate links and that purchases happen on store websites.

WHAT TO DO HERE

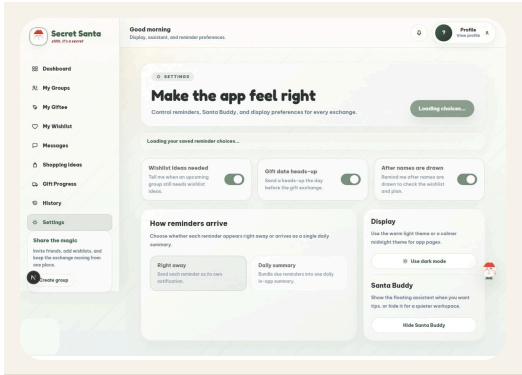
Keep it linked from the landing footer and shopping-related screens.

WATCH FOR

Update it when Amazon, Lazada, Shopee, or another affiliate partner is added or removed.

Preferences and owner-only reporting

These are not always visible to every user.



Reminder Preferences

/reminders

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

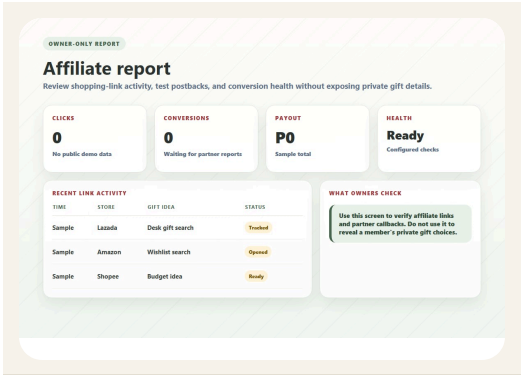
Fine-tunes wishlist reminders, gift-date reminders, post-draw reminders, display mode, and Santa Buddy.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Choose reminders that help without becoming noisy, then save.

WATCH FOR

This screen is under Settings, so many users will not need it on day one.



Affiliate Report

/dashboard/affiliate-report

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Owner-only reporting for shopping-link activity, affiliate health, and partner callback checks.

WHAT TO DO HERE

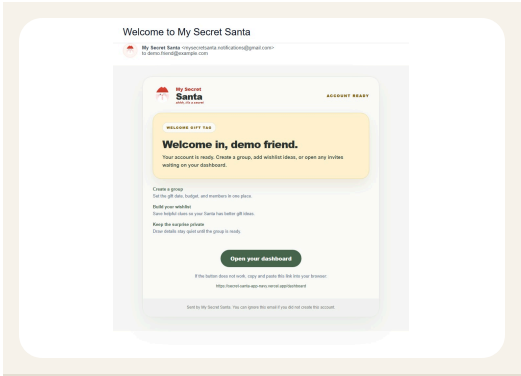
Use it to confirm affiliate systems are healthy without exposing private gift choices.

WATCH FOR

The screenshot is a sanitized sample. Live report access should stay restricted.

Email events

These are transactional messages, not app pages, but they are part of the user flow.



Welcome Email

email

WHAT THIS EVENT IS FOR

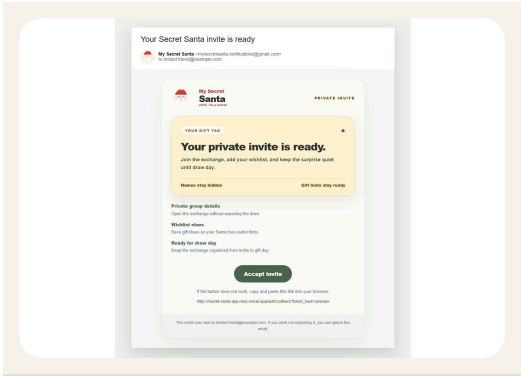
Confirms the account is ready and points the user back to their dashboard.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Open the dashboard, create a group, add wishlist clues, or check waiting invites.

WATCH FOR

Use demo recipients in screenshots. Do not publish real account emails or private links.



Invite Email

email

WHAT THIS EVENT IS FOR

Sends a private invitation with a clear accept button and enough context to trust the exchange.

WHAT TO DO HERE

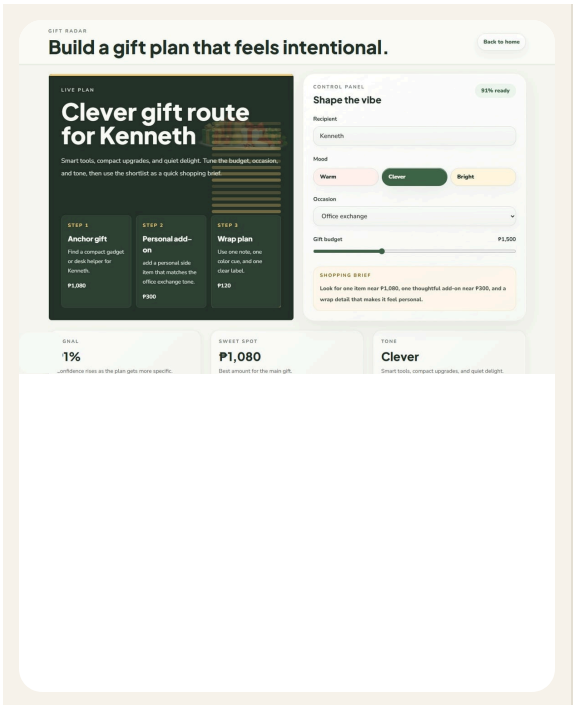
Recipients open the invite, accept, then add wishlist clues before the draw.

WATCH FOR

Do not publish real invite links or real recipient emails in demos.

Gift helper route

This is public and useful, but it is separate from the private exchange workspace.



Gift Radar

/cool-app

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

A public gift-planning helper used as a design and interaction guardrail route.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Use it as a lightweight gift brief experiment, not as the main exchange workspace.

WATCH FOR

If this stays public, keep copy clear so users do not confuse it with the private Shopping Ideas screen.

What is not a screenshot screen

These routes still matter, but they do not need their own visual page in the guide.

Redirect or callback routes

- **/assignments** redirects to My Giftee.
- **/auth/callback** completes sign-in and sends the user to the dashboard or saved next page.
- **/go/suggestion** and **/go/wishlist-link** are shopping redirect helpers, not user screens.

API and scheduled routes

- Affiliate postbacks, health checks, and matching APIs return data or process partner events.
- Wishlist suggestion APIs return gift ideas to the app, not standalone pages.
- Reminder processing routes run background work and should not be public demo screens.

Main exchange captured

Dashboard, groups, group workspace, wishlist, giftee, shopping, messages, progress, notifications, reveal, history.

Support captured

Login, create account, invite, forgot password, reset password, profile, settings, reminders.

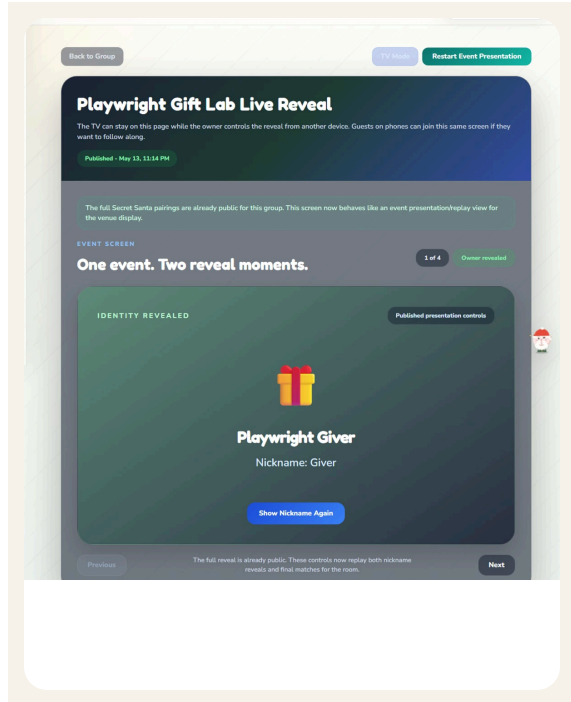
Public trust captured

Landing, how-it-works, privacy, terms, affiliate disclosure, welcome email, invite email, gift helper, affiliate report sample.

REVEAL DAY

How to finish the exchange well

The reveal is the moment people care about most. Keep it calm and clear.



Live Reveal

[/group/\[id\]/reveal](/group/[id]/reveal)

WHAT THIS SCREEN IS FOR

Turns the exchange into a shared event screen for the room, the TV, or members following along from their own devices.

WHAT TO DO HERE

Use the reveal controls when everyone is ready. Move through nickname reveals and final pairings at the group's pace.

WATCH FOR

Do not publish or replay the reveal early. Before reveal time, match details should stay hidden.

Reveal-day checklists

Use these right before the exchange becomes public to the group.

Reveal-day checklist for organizers

- ☐ Confirm the group has completed the draw.
- ☐ Check that gifts are ready or delivered as expected.
- ☐ Open the reveal screen before everyone gathers.
- ☐ Use the live reveal controls at the group's pace.
- ☐ Publish the group reveal only when it is okay for everyone to see.

Reveal-day checklist for members

- ☐ Bring or deliver the gift before the agreed time.
- ☐ Do not announce your giftee until the reveal starts.
- ☐ Confirm received gifts only after they arrive.
- ☐ Join the reveal screen if the organizer shares it.
- ☐ Enjoy the reveal and thank your Santa.

Plain-language reveal rule: before reveal day, keep your giftee private. After reveal day, the group can celebrate and remember who picked each name.

If something changes at the last minute

Use group messages or reminders to coordinate without spoiling matches. If a person drops out before the draw, update the group before drawing names. If the draw has already happened, the organizer should review the reset impact before changing assignments.

Keep the surprise safe

These rules help the app stay useful and comfortable for normal groups.

What stays private before reveal

- Who is gifting whom.
- Private Secret Santa questions.
- Gift progress that should only help planning.
- Personal account and profile details that are not needed by the group.

What people may see

- Group name, gift day, budget, and general setup.
- Member display names or festive avatars.
- Wishlist clues meant to help gift planning.
- Reveal results after the group intentionally reveals them.

Do

- Use fake demo data when recording tutorials.
- Keep wishlist notes respectful.
- Use the budget as a guide.
- Report suspicious access or privacy issues.

Do not

- Share screenshots that reveal another person's giftee.
- Paste secrets, account codes, or private documents into wishlists.
- Use someone else's invite link.
- Record real emails or private messages in public demos.

Shopping note

- Some shopping links may be affiliate links.
- Stores have their own checkout and privacy rules.
- The app helps with planning, not store order support.

For privacy, deletion, or security requests, contact mysecretsanta.notifications@gmail.com.

Common questions and fixes

Use this as a quick support reference.

I do not have a group yet.

Go to My Groups or Create Group. If you are joining someone else's exchange, ask the organizer for an invite.

My invite link does not work.

It may be expired, already used, or mistyped. Ask the organizer to resend the invite or check the email address.

I do not see my giftee.

The organizer may not have drawn names yet, or you may not be in the right group. Check the group page first.

My wishlist says it needs clues.

Add at least a few clear gift ideas. Include notes about sizes, colors, interests, or links if helpful.

I forgot my password.

Use the forgot-password page. If you signed in with Google, use Google sign-in again instead of a password reset.

I cannot upload a profile photo.

Try a smaller JPG or PNG, then refresh and try again. If it still fails, use a festive avatar for now.

Shopping links confuse me.

Use them as search helpers. Always check price, store, shipping, and fit before buying.

Someone joined by mistake.

Fix the member list before drawing names. If names were already drawn, the organizer should review reset impact first.

I received no email.

Check spam, promotions, and the email address used. You can often continue by signing in and checking the dashboard.

Can the organizer see every match?

The organizer manages the exchange, but the app is designed to avoid exposing matches before reveal actions are ready.

Use these before launch or gift day

These are intentionally short so an organizer can scan them fast.

Organizer setup checklist

- ☐ Group name is clear.
- ☐ Gift day and time are correct.
- ☐ Budget is written in the right currency.
- ☐ Invite list has the correct people.
- ☐ Group notes explain anything special.
- ☐ Members know to add wishlist clues.

Pre-draw checklist

- ☐ Accepted members are correct.
- ☐ No accidental invite is still active.
- ☐ Wishlist clues are ready enough.
- ☐ Everyone understands the budget.
- ☐ The organizer is ready to draw names.
- ☐ Members know where to check their giftee.

Participant gift checklist

- ☐ I accepted the invite.
- ☐ I added wishlist clues for my Santa.
- ☐ I checked my giftee after the draw.
- ☐ I chose a gift within budget.
- ☐ I updated gift progress.
- ☐ I kept my giftee secret until reveal day.

Demo recording checklist

- ☐ Use demo accounts only.
- ☐ Use fake names and fake wishlist items.
- ☐ Hide browser bookmarks and extensions.
- ☐ Do not show real emails, tokens, or admin dashboards.
- ☐ Record slowly enough for captions or viewers to follow.
- ☐ Review the recording before sharing it publicly.